

story would become the most subversive—and liberating—passage in the American Dream.

The first writer of that story was Obama himself. The highly literary *Dreams from My Father*, his memoirs at the age of 34, was an ambitious young man's ancestral manifesto. In retrospect, it was the first draft of his political dream—and the act of dreaming itself was an audacity then. He knew: he had to be the chronicler of his own story, and as a storyteller, he would make it exceptional and exotic, making the job of future biographers all the more challenging. Remnick too revisits the world of *Dreams from My Father* and *The Audacity of Hope* (which, unlike the first, is written by a politician who has already lost some of his literary élan), but the triumph of *The Bridge*, which ends with his Inauguration, is that it weaves the thriller that was the Obama campaign into the larger saga of America's racial anxieties. Dramatic, anecdotal, and sprinkled with vignettes from history, *The Bridge* traces the Obama journey, stretching from Kenya, the country of his African father, to the White House. What

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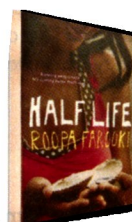
fascinates Remnick the most is the achievement of his subject—the son of a black man and a white woman—in refusing to get entrapped in the racial stereotype, in overcoming Jeremiah “God Damn America” Wright, in repudiating the sentimentalism of colour and presenting himself to America as “a man who had lived in both worlds, black and white”.

The title of this book takes us back to a poignant moment in the civil rights movement: the crossing of the Edmund Pettus Bridge in Selma, Alabama. In the first month of his campaign, in March 2007, the freshman senator from Illinois came to speak at the Brown Chapel in the city that was described by Martin Luther King Jr four decades ago as “a symbol of bitter-end resistance to the civil-rights movement in the Deep South.” Obama came as the inheritor of “Bloody Sunday” (March 7, 1965), the highlight of which was the protesters reaching the Edmund Pettus Bridge. He was only three when King, in his poetic flourish, responded to the battle of Selma: “How long? Not long, because no lie can live forever/How long? Not long, because you shall reap what you sow/How long? Not long, because the arc of the moral universe is long but it bends toward justice.” Barack Hussein Obama loves the last line. It is the shortest summary of his life. ■

Tortured Lives

Uplifting prose saves a depressing tale of complex relations and addictions

| By Dilip Bobb |



HALF LIFE
by ROOPA FAROOKI
Macmillan
Price: \$5.99
Pages: 258

There's a line in this novel about the protagonist, Aruna, and the “swinging pendulum in her head that told her sometimes she could be very, very good and sometimes she would be horrid. She could run away but she couldn't escape.” There's a pendulum-like rhythm to this book as it follows Aruna's tortured journey from a flat in East London and an English husband to Little India in Singapore, a life she had run away from but cannot escape, to a hospital in Kuala Lumpur

where an old man lies dying: the stage for the emotional and physical minefield which is *Half Life*.

Roopa Farooki's novel has shades of Monica Ali's *Brick Lane*, riding the edge of despair and hope, love and brutality, sex and revulsion, friendship and betrayal. It's also a strange mix of lyrical, uplifting prose and an utterly depressing story. *Half Life* refers to Aruna's own tragic progression and her conclusion that it is better to have lived half a life than none at all. Right through the narrative, guilt and betrayal and dark secrets dominate, so much so that it's almost impossible to empathise with Aruna. She is hooked to drugs and alcohol and random sex, decides to leave her husband on an impulse, returns to Singapore and her former lover only to discover that it is impossible for them to be together and then finds another darker secret, a medical condition that reduces her to half a life.

Farooki is a gifted writer with the ability to put together descriptions and emotions with passion and purpose. It's just that halfway through the book, a sense of impending doom takes over. Yet, despite the fact that Aruna is not an easy character to like, her self-destructive journey is compelling and sensitively handled. Moments of emotional bleakness are rendered bearable by the beauty of the language. This is contemporary storytelling about contemporary issues and the complex connections between marriage, sex, family and friendship. Farooki is another name to add to the stable of writers from Pakistan earning literary acclaim. She was born in Lahore but has spent most of her life in London and this is her fourth novel, all with an ethnic base, and easily her best. It's not a coming of age story as much as a coming home story, and as this book proves, running away is the easy part, returning home is much harder. ■